

Word family: **mean / means / meant / meaning / meaningful / meaningless**

Base word: mean

Past tense / past participle: **meant**

Part of speech: **verb, adjective, noun**

Important family note:

This is a particularly rich family because **mean** contains several genuinely distinct modern branches:

* **mean = 意思是 / 表示**

* **mean = 意指 / 指的是**

* **mean = 打算**

* **mean = 意味着 / 帶來某結果**

* **mean = 對某人很重要**

* **mean = 刻薄的**

* **mean = 吝嗇的**

* **mean = 平均的**

* **the mean = 平均數**

* **means = 方法 / 手段**

* **means = 財力 / 經濟能力**

Your database already contains **meaning**, so I'll keep the focus here on **mean** and only reference the **meaning** branch where it helps distinguish the senses rather than re-curating that whole entry.

Meaning in this passage

> Before meeting him, I used to think studying **meant** memorising facts and repeating them in exams.

Here, **meant** means:

to consist of or involve something as its essential nature — 意味着；就是指；等於要

The speaker previously believed that “studying” essentially consisted of memorising facts and reproducing them in exams.

中文翻譯：

在認識他之前，我一直以為讀書**就是意味着 / 就是要**背誦資料，然後在考試中重複寫出來。

More naturally:

> 在認識他之前，我一直以為讀書**就是背誦資料，再在考試中重複寫出來**。

So here:

X means doing Y = X 就是 / 意味着要做 Y

1. **mean = 意思是；表示**

This is the core semantic-definition sense.

Practice 1

> What does this word **mean**?

這個字是甚麼**意思**？

Practice 2

> “Rapid” **means** “very fast.”

rapid 的意思是「非常快」。

MCQ-ready definition:

mean = 某個字、符號、說法或行為所表達的意思是.....

2. **What do you mean? — 你是甚麼意思？**

A very common conversational pattern.

Practice 1

> What do you **mean** by that?

你那樣說是**甚麼意思**？

Practice 2

> I'm not sure what you **mean**.

我不太明白你的**意思**。

MCQ-ready definition:

****what do you mean? = 詢問對方剛才的說話究竟想表達甚麼****

3. **mean by something — 所謂.....是甚麼意思**

Practice 1

> What do you **mean by “independent thinking”?**

你所說的「獨立思考」是****甚麼意思****？

Practice 2

> I understand what she **means by “balance.”**

我明白她所說的「平衡」****指的是甚麼****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****mean by X = 使用 X 時所想表達的具體意思****

4. **mean that... — 表示；意思是.....**

Practice 1

> A red light **means that you must stop.**

紅燈****表示你必須停下來****。

Practice 2

> His silence didn't **mean that he agreed.**

他的沉默並不****表示他同意****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****mean that... = 某個訊號、行為或情況表示某件事是真的****

5. **mean something by an action — 某個行為有某種意思**

Practice 1

> What did he **mean** by that smile?

他那個笑容**是甚麼意思**？

Practice 2

> I didn't **mean** anything by it.

我那樣做**沒有甚麼特別意思** / 不是有心暗示甚麼。

MCQ-ready definition:

mean something by an action = 透過某個行為有意表達某種訊息或意圖

6. **X means doing Y** — 意味着要.....；就是.....

This is the **exact pattern** used in your passage.

Practice 1 — original sentence

> I used to think studying **meant** memorising facts.

我以前一直以為讀書**就是要背誦資料**。

Practice 2

> Being a teacher **means** working with people every day.

當老師**意味着每天都要和人相處**。

Practice 3

> Learning a language **means** making mistakes sometimes.

學習語言**意味着有時候會犯錯**。

MCQ-ready definition:

X means doing Y = Y 是 X 必然包含、涉及或要求的一部分

7. **mean** = 意味着；會導致某種結果

Closely related to the previous sense, but here the focus is **consequence**.

Practice 1

> Missing the bus will **mean waiting another hour**.

錯過巴士就**意味着要再等一個小時**。

Practice 2

> A delay could **mean higher costs**.

延誤可能**意味着成本增加**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****mean = 某件事會帶來、造成或必然涉及某個結果****

8. **mean the difference between X and Y — 決定 X 與 Y 的差別**

Practice 1

> One small decision can **mean the difference between success and failure**.

一個小決定可能**決定成敗**。

Practice 2

> Good preparation can **mean the difference between passing and failing**.

充分準備可能**決定你合格還是不合格**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****mean the difference between X and Y = 成為決定兩種結果中哪一種出現的關鍵因素****

9. **mean to do something — 打算做某事**

A major separate verb sense.

Practice 1

> I **meant to call you** yesterday.

我昨天本來**打算打電話給你**。

Practice 2

> She **meant to finish** the report before lunch.

她本來**打算**午飯前完成**報告**。

MCQ-ready definition:

mean to do something = 有做某件事的打算或意圖

10. **didn't mean to do something** — 不是故意的；無意做某事

Very common.

Practice 1

> I **didn't mean to hurt you**.

我**不是故意**要傷害你**。**

Practice 2

> He **didn't mean to interrupt**.

他**不是有意**打斷別人**。**

MCQ-ready definition:

didn't mean to do something = 並沒有故意或有意圖去做某事

11. **mean for someone to do something** — 打算讓某人做某事

Practice 1

> I **meant for you to read this first**.

我本來**打算**讓你先讀這個**。**

Practice 2

> She never **meant for things to become so complicated**.

她從來沒有**打算**讓事情變得這麼複雜**。**

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****mean for someone/something to do X = 有意安排或希望某人 / 某事出現某個結果****

12. ****be meant to do something — 原本應該；設計來；預定要****

This is a highly important multifunctional construction.

Practice 1

> This button is ****meant to open the door****.

這個按鈕****是用來開門的****。

Practice 2

> We were ****meant to meet at six****.

我們****原定六點見面****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****be meant to do something = 被設計、安排、預定或預期去做某事****

13. ****be meant for someone/something — 是為……而設 / 準備的****

Practice 1

> This book is ****meant for beginners****.

這本書****是為初學者而寫的****。

Practice 2

> These exercises are ****meant for younger students****.

這些練習****是為較年輕學生而設的****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****be meant for X = 特別為 X 的用途、需要或使用而設計 / 準備****

14. ****be meant for each other — 天生一對；很適合彼此****

A fixed figurative expression.

Practice 1

> They seem to be ****meant for each other****.

他們看起來真是****天生一對****。

Practice 2

> Everyone said the couple were ****meant for each other****.

大家都說那對情侶****非常合襯****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****be meant for each other = 兩個人在性格或感情上非常適合成為伴侶****

15. ****mean something to someone — 對某人有意義 / 很重要****

A major emotional sense.

Practice 1

> His advice ****meant a lot to me****.

他的建議****對我來說很重要****。

Practice 2

> This photograph ****means a great deal to her****.

這張照片****對她意義重大****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****mean something/a lot to someone = 對某人具有重要的感情、價值或個人意義****

16. ****mean nothing to someone — 對某人毫無意義 / 不重要****

Practice 1

> Money ****means nothing to him**** compared with family.

和家庭相比，金錢**對他來說並不重要**。

Practice 2

> That title **means nothing to me**.

那個頭銜**對我沒有甚麼意義**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****mean nothing to someone = 對某人沒有重要性、價值或感情意義****

17. **mean well — 出於好意**

A very useful fixed expression.

Practice 1

> I know she **means well**.

我知道她是**出於好意**。

Practice 2

> He sometimes gives too much advice, but he **means well**.

他有時給太多意見，但其實是**好心的**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****mean well = 有良好意圖，即使實際結果未必理想****

18. **mean no harm — 沒有惡意**

Practice 1

> I **meant no harm**.

我**沒有惡意**。

Practice 2

> She **meant no harm by the comment**.

她說那句話**並沒有惡意**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****mean no harm = 沒有傷害、冒犯或造成問題的意圖****

19. ****mean business — 是認真的；來真的****

Practice 1

> When she sets a deadline, she ****means business****.

她定下死線時可是****認真的****。

Practice 2

> His expression showed that he ****meant business****.

他的表情顯示他這次是****來真的****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****mean business = 對某件事非常認真，確實準備採取行動****

20. ****mean what you say — 說話是認真的****

Practice 1

> Do you really ****mean what you say****?

你說的話****真的算數嗎 / 是認真的嗎****？

Practice 2

> She always ****means what she says****.

她說話一向****是認真的、說到做到****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****mean what you say = 真心認同自己所說的話，而非隨便說說****

21. **mean (adjective : 刻薄的) — 刻薄的 ; 不友善的**

A completely different major adjective branch.

Practice 1

> That was a **mean thing to say**.

那句話說得很**刻薄**。

Practice 2

> Don't be **mean to your brother**.

不要對你弟弟那麼**刻薄 / 不好**。

MCQ-ready definition:

mean = 故意以不友善、傷人或令人難受的方式對待別人的

22. **be mean to someone — 對某人刻薄 / 欺負某人**

Practice 1

> The other children were **mean to him**.

其他孩子對他很**刻薄**。

Practice 2

> Why are you being **mean to her**?

你為甚麼對她這麼**不好 / 刻薄**?

MCQ-ready definition:

be mean to someone = 對某人不友善、苛刻或故意令其難受

23. **mean (吝嗇的) — 吝嗇的 ; 小器的**

Especially common in BrE.

Practice 1

> He's too **mean to buy** anyone a drink.

他太**吝嗇**，連請人喝杯東西也不願意。

Practice 2

> Don't be **mean with the food**.

食物不要給得那麼**小氣**。

MCQ-ready definition:

mean = 不願意花錢、分享或給予應有份量的

24. **mean with money** — 對金錢很吝嗇

Practice 1

> He's rather **mean with money**.

他對錢相當**吝嗇**。

Practice 2

> She isn't rich, but she's never **mean with her friends**.

她雖然不富有，但對朋友從不**小器**。

MCQ-ready definition:

mean with money/resources = 過分不願花費或分享金錢 / 資源

25. **mean (卑劣的 ; 不光彩的)** — 卑劣的 ; 低劣的

A more formal/older but still current extension of the “unkind” branch.

Practice 1

> It was a **mean trick**.

那是一個很**卑劣**的手段。

Practice 2

> He played a **mean trick** on his friend.

他對朋友使了一個很**惡劣的把戲**。

MCQ-ready definition:

mean = 行為低劣、不光彩或故意令人受到傷害的

26. **mean** (average : 平均的) — 平均的

A completely separate technical/statistical adjective sense.

Practice 1

> The **mean temperature** was 20°C.

平均氣溫是攝氏 20 度。

Practice 2

> We calculated the **mean score** for the class.

我們計算了全班的**平均分數**。

MCQ-ready definition:

mean = 以全部數值的總和除以數值數量所得的平均水平

27. **the mean** (平均數 ; 算術平均數) — 平均數

Here **mean** is a noun.

Practice 1

> The **mean** of 2, 4, and 6 is 4.

2、4、6 的**平均數**是 4。

Practice 2

> Calculate the **mean** of these values.

計算這些數值的**平均數**。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****the mean = 把所有數值相加，再除以數值個數所得的數****

28. ****means (方法；手段) — 方法；手段****

Very important: ****means**** is lexicalized and has the same form in singular and plural in this sense.

Practice 1

> Email is a useful ****means of communication****.

電郵是一種有用的****溝通方式****。

Practice 2

> We need to find a ****means of solving the problem****.

我們需要找到一種****解決問題的方法****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****means = 用來達成某個目的的方法、方式或工具****

29. ****a means of doing something — 做某事的方法****

Practice 1

> Exercise is a good ****means of reducing stress****.

運動是****減輕壓力的一種方法****。

Practice 2

> Language is a ****means of expressing ideas****.

語言是一種****表達思想的工具 / 方式****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****a means of doing X = 用來完成 X 或達到某目的的方法****

30. ****by means of — 藉着；透過****

Practice 1

> They entered the building **by means of a side door**.

他們**經由側門**進入大樓。

Practice 2

> The device is controlled **by means of an app**.

這部裝置**透過應用程式**控制。

MCQ-ready definition:

by means of X = 使用 X 作為達成某事的方法或工具

31. **by all means** — 當然可以；儘管

A fixed idiom.

Practice 1

> “Can I ask a question?” “**By all means.**”

「我可以問個問題嗎？」

「**當然可以。**」

Practice 2

> **By all means**, use my notes.

儘管 / 當然可以用我的筆記。

MCQ-ready definition:

by all means = 表示完全同意或允許某人做某事

32. **by no means** — 絕不；一點也不

Practice 1

> The task is **by no means easy**.

這項工作**絕不容易**。

Practice 2

> He is **by no means a beginner**.

他**絕對不是初學者**。

MCQ-ready definition:

by no means = 一點也不；絕對不是

33. **a means to an end — 達到目的的手段**

Practice 1

> For him, money was only **a means to an end**.

對他而言，金錢只是**達成目的的手段**。

Practice 2

> Exams should not become merely **a means to an end**.

考試不應只是**達到另一目的的工具**。

MCQ-ready definition:

a means to an end = 本身不是最終目的，只是用來達成另一目標的方法

34. **the means to do something — 做某事所需的財力 / 資源**

Here **means** shifts from “method” to **resources, especially money**.

Practice 1

> They don't have the **means to buy a house**.

他們沒有**足夠財力**買房。

Practice 2

> Education should be available to people regardless of their **means**.

教育不應因個人**經濟能力**而有所限制。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****means = 一個人可運用的金錢、財產或其他資源****

35. ****a person of means — 富有的人****

Practice 1

> He came from a family of ****means****.

他出身於一個****富裕家庭****。

Practice 2

> Only people of considerable ****means**** could afford it.

只有相當****富有的人****才負擔得起。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****a person of means = 擁有相當財富或經濟資源的人****

36. ****live within your means — 量入為出****

Practice 1

> It's important to ****live within your means****.

****量入為出****很重要。

Practice 2

> They learned to ****live within their means****.

他們學會了****按自己的經濟能力生活****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****live within your means = 花費不超過自己能負擔的收入和財力****

37. ****live beyond your means — 入不敷支；超出能力消費****

Practice 1

> He had been **living beyond his means**.

他一直**花費超出自己的經濟能力**。

Practice 2

> Don't borrow money just to **live beyond your means**.

不要借錢來維持**超出自己負擔能力的生活**。

MCQ-ready definition:

live beyond your means = 花費超過自己的收入或財力所能承擔的水平

38. **means-tested** — 須按收入 / 資產審查的

A common public-policy compound.

Practice 1

> The benefit is **means-tested**.

這項福利需要接受**入息 / 資產審查**。

Practice 2

> They applied for **means-tested support**.

他們申請了**須經經濟審查的援助**。

MCQ-ready definition:

means-tested = 是否符合資格取決於申請人的收入、財產或經濟能力的

Important distinction 1: **mean** = 意思是 vs **mean** = 意味着

Semantic meaning

> What does this word **mean**?

這個字是甚麼意思？

Consequence/involvement

> Being late **means missing the beginning**.

遲到就意味着錯過開頭。

The first explains **meaning**; the second explains **consequence or necessary involvement**.

Important distinction 2: **mean doing vs mean to do**

Extremely important.

mean doing

= 涉及 / 意味着做.....

> Being a teacher **means working hard**.

當老師意味着要努力工作。

mean to do

= 打算做.....

> I **meant to call you**.

我本來打算打電話給你。

This is one of the most important grammar contrasts in the whole family.

Important distinction 3: **didn't mean to vs didn't want to**

didn't mean to

= it was not intentional.

didn't want to

= had no desire to.

> I didn't mean to upset her.

我不是故意令她不開心。

You might have wanted to say something, but not intended the harmful result.

Important distinction 4: ****be meant to vs should****

****be meant to****

can mean:

- * designed to
- * intended to
- * scheduled to
- * supposed to

****should****

gives advice, expectation, or obligation.

> This tool is meant to cut glass.

這工具是設計來切玻璃的。

> You should be careful.

你應該小心。

Important distinction 5: ****mean something to someone vs mean something****

****mean something****

= have a definition/significance.

****mean something to someone****

= have personal importance.

> What does this symbol mean?

這符號代表甚麼？

> This gift means a lot to me.

這份禮物對我意義重大。

Important distinction 6: **mean well vs do well**

mean well

have good intentions.

do well

perform successfully.

Someone can **mean well** but still do something badly.

Important distinction 7: **mean vs rude**

mean

deliberately unkind/hurtful.

rude

impolite.

Someone can be rude accidentally; **mean** more strongly suggests unkindness.

Important distinction 8: **mean vs cruel**

mean

unkind, often in ordinary interpersonal behaviour.

cruel

stronger: deliberately causes suffering or shows lack of compassion.

So **cruel** is usually more severe.

Important distinction 9: **mean vs strict**

Very important in a teacher passage.

strict

enforces rules firmly.

mean

unkind or deliberately unpleasant.

A teacher can be strict but completely fair and kind.

So:

strict ≠ mean

Important distinction 10: **mean = 刻薄 vs mean = 吝嗇**

These are related but distinct.

People treatment

> She's mean to him.

她對他很刻薄。

Money/resources

> He's mean with money.

他很吝嗇。

The preposition often helps distinguish them.

Important distinction 11: **mean vs stingy**

mean (BrE)

can mean unwilling to spend/share money.

****stingy****

specifically means excessively unwilling to give or spend.

> He's mean with money.

> He's stingy.

Very close in this sense.

Important distinction 12: ****mean vs average****

In statistics:

****mean****

is one specific type of average.

****average****

in everyday English is broader.

The arithmetic mean is:

> $\text{total} \div \text{number of values}$

But statistical “average” may loosely refer to mean, median, or another central measure depending on context.

Important distinction 13: ****mean vs median vs mode****

For statistics:

****mean****

$\text{sum} \div \text{number of values}$

****median****

middle value when ordered

mode

most frequent value

These should never be treated as interchangeable technical terms.

Important distinction 14: **means singular/plural grammar**

For **means = 方法**, the form stays the same.

Singular

> a **means** of communication

一種溝通方式

Plural

> several **means** of communication

幾種溝通方式

Not:

> *a mean of communication* ❌

This is a major learner trap.

Important distinction 15: **means = method vs means = money/resources**

Method

> a means of transport

交通方式

Resources

> people of limited means

經濟能力有限的人

Same word, distinctly different meaning.

Important distinction 16: **by all means** vs **by no means**

Almost opposites.

by all means

= 當然可以

by no means

= 絕不；一點也不

Learners should memorize these as fixed expressions.

Important distinction 17: **means** vs **way**

way

very broad, everyday word.

means

more formal and often emphasizes a method used to achieve a result.

> a way to learn

學習方法

> a means of communication

溝通手段

Important distinction 18: **means** vs **resource**

means

can refer collectively to resources available to achieve something.

resource

a specific useful asset, supply, tool, person, etc.

> financial means

財力

> educational resources

教育資源

Important distinction 19: **meant** = past tense of mean**

The form is irregular:

> mean → **meant** → meant

Not:

> *meaned* ✗

So your passage:

> studying **meant** memorising...

uses the past tense of **mean**.

Family-extension note

Mean is one of the richest high-frequency polysemy families because several very different modern branches coexist under the same spelling.

The major branches are:

1. **semantic meaning**

* What does X mean?

* mean by X

2. **involve / entail / result in**

- * studying means memorising
- * this means waiting

3. **intention**

- * mean to do
- * didn't mean to
- * mean well
- * mean no harm

4. **intended purpose**

- * be meant to
- * be meant for

5. **personal significance**

- * mean a lot to someone

6. **unkindness**

- * mean person
- * mean to someone

7. **stinginess**

- * mean with money

8. **statistics**

- * mean score
- * the mean

9. **method**

- * a means of communication
- * by means of

10. **financial resources**

- * people of means
- * live within your means

This is exactly the sort of word where **POS shift + grammar construction + lexicalized plural form** create genuinely different learner meanings.

Master comparison

Form / expression	Traditional Chinese	Core idea	
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mean (word/sign)	意思是；表示	semantic meaning	
mean by X	所謂 X 是指.....	intended meaning	
mean that...	表示.....	implication	
X means doing Y	X 意味着 / 涉及 Y	entailment	
mean higher costs	意味着成本增加	consequence	
mean to do X	打算做 X	intention	
didn't mean to X	不是故意 X	lack of intention	
mean for X to happen	打算讓 X 發生	intended outcome	
be meant to X	原定 / 設計來 X	intended purpose	
be meant for X	為 X 而設	intended recipient	
meant for each other	天生一對	ideal compatibility	
mean a lot to X	對 X 很重要	personal significance	
mean well	出於好意	good intention	
mean no harm	沒有惡意	harmless intention	
mean business	是認真的	serious intention	
mean what you say	說話是認真的	genuine statement	
mean (unkind)	刻薄的	unkind	
mean to someone	對某人刻薄	unkind treatment	
mean (stingy)	吝嗇的	unwilling to give/spend	
mean trick	卑劣手段	nasty action	
mean (average adj.)	平均的	arithmetic average	
the mean	平均數	statistical value	
a means	方法；手段	method	
means of X	X 的方式 / 手段	instrument/method	
by means of	藉着；透過	using	
by all means	當然可以	permission	
by no means	絕不；一點也不	strong negation	
means to an end	達成目的的手段	instrumental method	
means (resources)	財力；經濟能力	financial resources	
person of means	富有的人	wealthy person	
within your means	量入為出	affordable spending	
beyond your means	超出負擔能力	unaffordable spending	
means-tested	經入息 / 資產審查的	eligibility by finances	

For your original sentence

> Before meeting him, I used to think studying **meant** memorising facts and repeating them in

exams**.

Here:

meant = 意味着 ; 就是包括 / 就是要

The speaker is describing their **old concept of what studying consisted of**.

It is **not**:

* **mean = 打算**

* **mean = 刻薄**

* **mean = 平均**

* **means = 方法**

The grammar is the key:

X means doing Y

= **X 就意味着 / 包含做 Y**

A very natural Traditional Chinese translation is:

> 在認識他之前，我一直以為讀書**就是背誦資料，然後在考試中把它們重複寫出來**。

For this passage, **「就是」** is actually the smoothest contextual translation, while the underlying lexical sense is **「意味着 / 包含」**.